Modals of deduction in the past

Goal: To make logical guesses about past events using **must have**, **may / might / could have** and **can't / couldn't have**, and to choose the modal that matches the degree of certainty.

The idea in two lines: When we are not sure what happened in the past, we deduce from evidence. The modal shows how certain we are, and it is always followed by have + past participle.

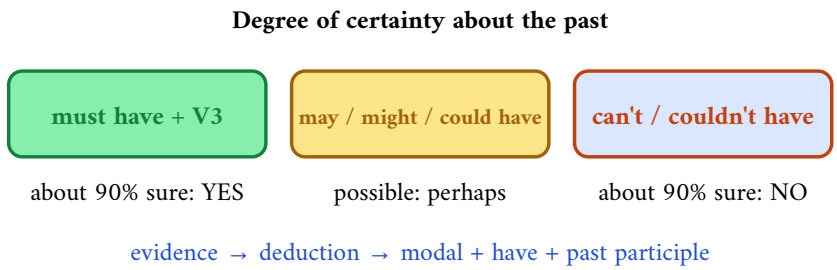


Figure 1: Three levels of past deduction, from positive certainty to negative certainty.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Structure:** subject + modal + have + past participle: *They must have used simple tools.*
2. **Must have** = strong positive deduction based on clear evidence.
3. **May / might / could have** = a possibility; we are not sure.
4. **Can't / couldn't have** = strong negative deduction; it seems impossible.
5. The opposite of *must have* in deduction is **can't have**, not *mustn't have*.
6. Passive form: modal + have been + past participle: *The temple may have been destroyed by an earthquake.*

🟢 Examples

1. Evidence: the city's walls were huge and thick. **Solution:** The inhabitants **must have feared** invasions. **Explanation:** strong evidence, so *must have*.

2. Rewrite: *It is impossible that one man built this monument alone.* **Solution:** One man **can't have built** this monument alone.
3. Rewrite: *Perhaps the city was abandoned because of drought.* **Solution:** The city **might have been abandoned** because of drought.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Writing *must have build* or *must had built*; the correct form is *must have built*.
- Using *mustn't have* for impossibility instead of *can't have*.
- Confusing deduction (*must have gone*) with past obligation (*had to go*).
- Choosing *must have* when the text gives no strong evidence.

🟡 Quick review

- Sure yes: must have + V3.
- Maybe: may / might / could have + V3.
- Sure no: can't / couldn't have + V3.
- Passive: modal + have been + V3.

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